The Physics of Artificial Intelligence

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March 2026

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Contents

0 The Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics **5**
0.1 What is Temperature? 5
0.2 The Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics 5
0.3 Thermal Expansion and Heat Absorption 5

Preface

Actually, I am not an AI or CS student. When the AI explosion occurred 3 years ago, I did not care about it so much. I thought it was a scam; created by the billionaires, who want to take control of the new world. I was not interested in AI in the first place. Everything was nonsense and meaningless, why did I have to care about it?

Like every student living in AI-era, I was forced to learn a subject called "Fundamental of Artificial Intelligence", 3 credits, in my third year. When the midterm came, I realized that I did not know anything; and the risk of failing this subject was real. 2 hours before midterm, I came to the library and tried to learn something that could save my grade above 4 points. To be honest, the feeling of just studying to merely pass a stupid test and then being done with it was so frustrating. I was watching many tutorial videos on YouTube, and thought "OK, the game is over. I am done.". My brain could not consume any knowledge from them. I was a failure.

Instead of learning like crazy in the last 2 hours left, I just skimmed all the stuffs for 1 hour, and decided to give up. Fortunately, I did misclick a video; this moment would change my vision forever.

"Geoffrey Hinton, Nobel Prize in Physics 2024: Banquet speech"

Wait, did something go wrong here? Nobel Prize in Physics for Artificial Intelligence? My brain turned on because I deeply cared about Physics. "Why did something bullshit receive a Nobel Prize, even in Physics?". I did some searching, and then I found some familiar keywords, such as "Boltzmann Statistics", "Spin-Glass", "Ising Model". "Perhaps I could do some Physics here.", I thought. Time flies so fast, half a year has already passed. I am still confused, but I think I have got an idea. After my first book "Thinking like a Frequentist" was published online, why not try writing about the "bridge" between Physics and AI? At least so far, I have not seen anyone write a sufficiently understandable document on this topic. But the problem is, I am not even a Physics student. Up to now, my Physics knowledge is limited to Halliday textbooks, and some experience with digital and analog electronics. To fill these gaps, I have to learn everything from scratch.

That is why I wrote this book as a concise self-study guide for anyone interested in Physics and AI. Unlike my first book, which was written when my knowledge of Probability and Statistics was already solid; this book was written during my self-study process. I may have made many mistakes or misinterpretations; but I hope you, my readers, can point them out and send feedbacks via email `tinvu1309@gmail.com`. I would be extremely happy if someone could discuss these issues with me.

The structure of this book contains 2 main parts: "Basic Knowledge of Physics" from Chapter 0 to **Chapter 7**, and "Physics and Artificial Intelligence" from **Chapter 8** to **Chapter 15**. Although I will try to keep everything as simple as possible; but before reading, you should be familiar with elementary university mathematics concepts, include: *Calculus*, *Linear Algebra* and *Probability and Statistics*. The better your math skills, the higher your physics ability. In physics, you need to understand some basic concepts of *Mechanics and Thermodynamics*; *Electromagnetism* and some applied physics subjects such as *Signals and Systems*, *Control Theory* and *Digital Signal Processing*. Some useful books and lecture notes are listed below:

1. Calculus: Calculus 7E, James Stewart
2. Linear Algebra: Elementary Linear Algebra, Larson - Edwards - Falvo
3. Probability and Statistics: Probability and Statistics for Engineers and Scientists, Walpole - Myers or Thinking like a Frequentist, Tin Vu
4. Mechanics and Thermodynamics, Electromagnetism: Fundamentals of Physics, Halliday and Resnick
5. Signals and Systems: Signals and Systems, Alan V. Oppenheim or my lecture note (Vietnamese)
6. Digital Signals Processing: My lecture note (Vietnamese)
7. Control Theory: Control Systems Engineering, Norman S. Nise or my lecture note (English)

I highly suggest that you should read the first part **without any AI tools** to build physics intuition (I did that too); before diving into the second part of this book, where we "wire" our intuition up with the aid of AI tools. Everything will turn out great as long as we keep trying.

Chapter 0

The Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics

0.1 What is Temperature?

If you touch an ice cube, you will feel cold; and if you touch boiling water, you will feel hot. Now you can conclude that ice cube is in low temperature, and boiling water is in high temperature. In common thinking, **temperature** is a quantity that used to measure hotness and coldness of objects. Instead of trusting our feeling, we often use a measuring device called **thermometer** to estimate the temperature.

Example 0.1.1. Using thermometer to measure the temperature of a cup of hot water.

After adjusting the thermometer to normal room temperature, immerse it into a cup; and wait until the mercury inside no longer rises. Now read the temperature displayed on the thermometer.
The waiting time is called **relaxation time**; the state when both thermometer and hot water sharing the same temperature is called **thermal equilibrium**.

0.2 The Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics

Definition 0.2.1 (The Zeroth Law of Thermodynamics)**.** *If object A and B are each in thermal equilibrium with a third object T, then A and B are in* ***thermal equilibrium*** *with each other.*

In spite of its simplicity, this law provides an independent definition of temperature without reference to any complex terminologies.

Corollary 0.2.0.1 (The First Definition of Temperature)**.** *Every object has a property called* ***temperature****. When two objects are in* ***thermal equilibrium****, their temperatures are* ***equal****.*

After reading the temperature of hot water in our cup (might be around 60°C), you wait for a while, and the mercury level inside thermometer slowly decreases. You carefully observe until the water has completely cooled down to room temperature. Finally, the mercury level stops decreasing, and at this point the room temperature, the water temperature, and the thermometer temperature are all the same (possibly 25°C), according to the law.

0.3 Thermal Expansion and Heat Absorption

Let's look closer to the experiment that we did. If I use a clock to measure time, I will obtain a simple graph:

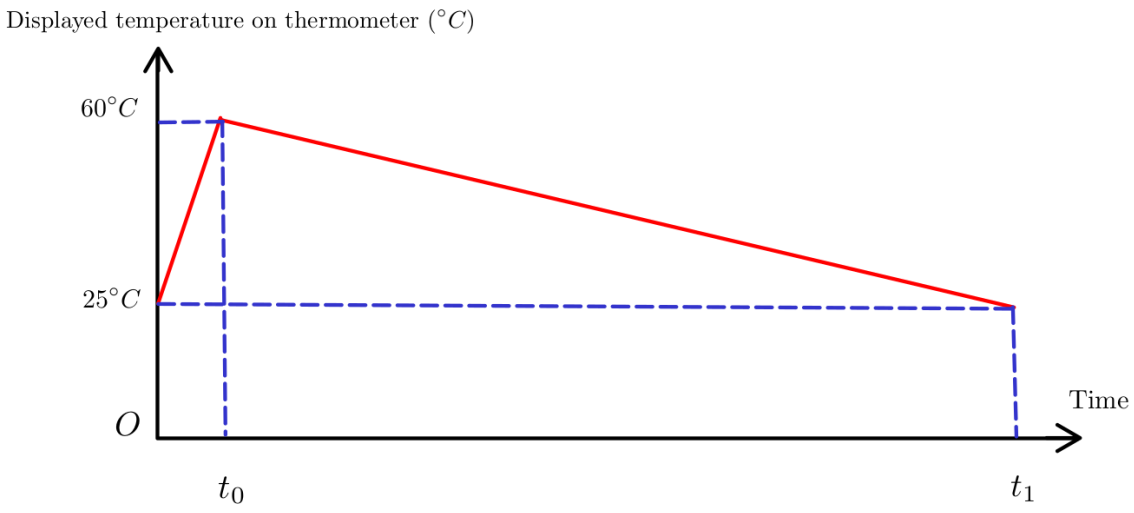

Figure 1: Relationship between time and thermometer's temperature

As you can see here, the time interval $(0, t_0)$ is very short compared to (t_0, t_1). Look at the first interval [1], why did the thermometer's temperature increase?

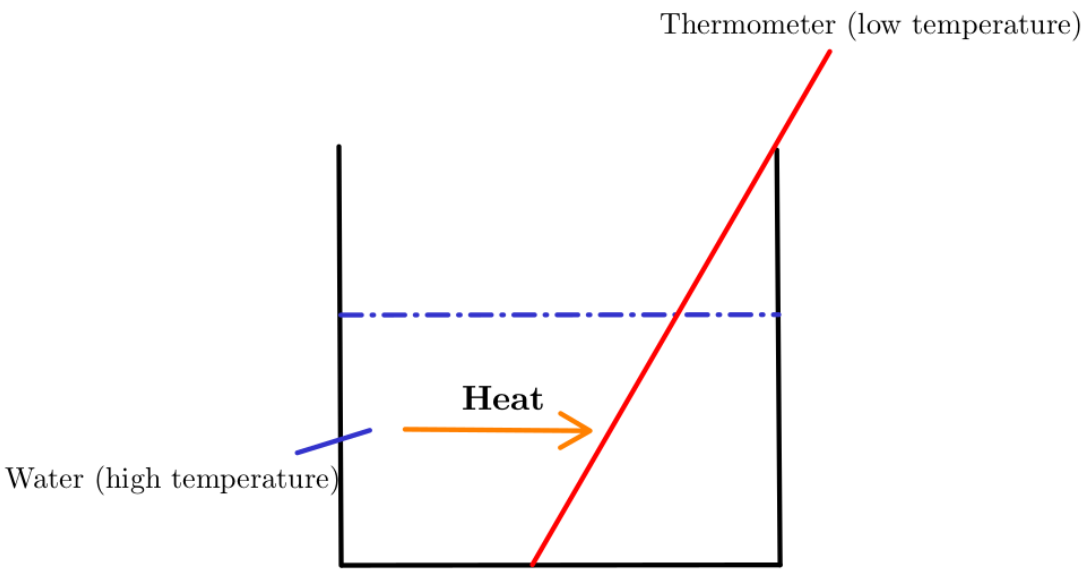

Figure 2: Heat flows between objects

The simplest explanation is that there is a "special energy" that transfers from a high-temperature object to a low-temperature object. This is very easy to imagine, and we call that "energy" as **heat** [2]. Now you might wonder "Why does not heat flow in the reverse direction?". This question will be explained carefully in the next chapters.

Definition 0.3.1 (Heat definition)**.** *Heat is the energy that* ***spontaneously*** *transfers from the higher temperature object to the lower temperature object.*

[1] For a very short period, the amount of energy transferred to the outside environment is negligible, so we can ignore it.

[2] **Heat** in this context is a **positive quantity**. I will explain the negative case later.

Because heat is a **transferring energy** between objects, so we have to be careful here:

Corollary 0.3.0.1. *A thermodynamics system* ***does not*** *contain heat.*

Now we can form the second definition of **temperature** bases on definition 0.3.1 as follows:

Definition 0.3.2 (The Second Definition of Temperature)**.** ***Temperature*** *is a measure of the tendency of an object to* ***spontaneously*** *give up energy to its surroundings.*